



Amazon's new drone shelter

Amazon explorers using street light as delivery drone perches for charging and shelter
dgit.in/AmazonDroneShelter



Birth of Spaceport

Capecanavel had first Rocket
 Bumper 8 launched on 24 July 1950
dgit.in/1stSpaceport

the Desert, a classic Russian twist on a Western film. On every launch, the crew even take a talisman with them, which, more often than not, is a stuffed animal toy! This one is halfway between superstition and science. The inanimate critter tied to the console serves as the mascot of the mission, but also performs the serious role of giving the crew a visual confirmation of having successfully left Earth, by floating. How cool are the rituals of spacebound Russians!

The only other nation that has been at it long enough to have dedicated space superstitions is the United States of America. If an astronaut does decide to have breakfast before the launch, you can bet it's going to be scrambled eggs and steak! This was the iconic last earth-breakfast devoured by the first Americans in space - Alan Shepard and John Glenn. However, in today's age of press conferences, the pre-launch breakfast is a more official affair. Another tradition permeating the pre-launch breakfast at NASA is that the crew is presented with a cake portraying the mission emblem. The tradition itself though, is that no one eats the cake. Perhaps deforming the emblem would be an ill omen, or perhaps no one was hungry the first time it was officially served. We'll never know.

NASA's Jet Propulsion Laboratory launched the Ranger mission in the 1960s, spaceflights intended to fly around and take photographs of the moon. However, the Ranger mission soon turned into a series of missions as all of the first six launches were unsuccessful. On the seventh try they got lucky, or perhaps they didn't get unlucky. Either way, the thing that was most noticeably different the seventh time was that someone had got a jar of peanuts to the control room and shared it around. Since then, mystical powers of sending Americans successfully to space have been attributed to peanuts in the control room.

While the Russian cosmonauts hydrate their bus tyres, their astronaut counterparts do their own thing en route to the launch pad. In this superstitious ritual, the crew plays poker and the cards continue to be dealt until the commander loses. Only then can the launch proceed.

On the Earth-ridden side, ever since STS-1, the director of the Launch Control Centre treats his co-workers to a meal of beans and cornbread after a successful launch, a time for celebration and bonding for the entire team.

Back home in our industrious nation, the act of faith chosen by our scientists



The place for official divine permission (for entering outer space) in India

is limited to seeking blessings, limited to a particular God in a particular temple. Various news agencies have reported that the scientists of ISRO enhance their odds by praying to Lord Balaji at Tirupati, often along with a miniature model of the launch vehicle. Dr. CNR Rao, an eminent scientist, has been quoted as terming this practice "superstitious". Yet, in the context of our entire nation, so steeped in various spiritual traditions, it hardly seems illogical! The only other remotely superstitious action was the naming of PSLV-14 directly after PSLV-12. Even if it was a decision based on imagined consequences, it is certainly a one-time deal. It is indeed great to know that ISRO concentrates where it should, on science!

Of course, in the uncertain and risky business of fighting gravity and sending people to space, it's no surprise that superstitions arise. The infinitely many variables and the complexity of their relationships ensures that no mortal (or group thereof) can comprehend the big picture, let alone sanely handle the pressure and responsibilities of such a launch event. If you noticed that the Russians have the more superstitions, you should also be informed that they have fewer fatalities. Maybe there is something to it after all. As long as it increases the odds, whatever the rationality, superstition is here to stay! 



Guess who lost the poker game?